> strong hint of how matters were going, I immediately ordered all the gates to be secured. At the same time I caused loop holes to be bored into the upper walls of Captain Troup's house [a short distance away] in which were stationed a naik [NCO] and ten sepoys. Whilst so employed, the armed population of Deh-i-Afghanan came pouring down through the gardens and began firing at us . . . One of my men was killed, and another badly wounded.

The attackers then occupied the whole of the Shah Bagh and could not be dislodged despite repeated sallies from the fort by Mackenzie's men, who continued to suffer casualties.

> The canal was cut off during the day, and so closely watched that one of my followers was shot while trying to fetch some water; but we fortunately found an old well, the water of which was drinkable. Towards the afternoon, having no ammunition but what was contained in the soldiers' pouches, I communicated with Capt Trevor who despatched my requisition for ammunition at least, but did not send assistance. Capt Lawrence's gallant offer to come to our aid, if loaned two companies, was refused [by Elphinstone and Macnaghten]. In the evening I served out provisions from the Government stores. The attacks continued at intervals during the night, and we had the most disagreeable suspicion that the enemy was undermining our northwest tower.[23]

That afternoon, while Mackenzie was fighting for his life, within the city the rebel leaders were reviewing their options. Until early afternoon they had all kept their horses saddled in case the expected British counter-attack broke through to their headquarters.[24] But it was becoming increasingly clear that the British were too shocked to respond in any coherent way, and several chiefs who had initially offered their services to them, seeing the failure of nerve in the cantonment, now began to drift away and to put out feelers instead to the rebels.[25] As Vincent Eyre commented: 'The murder of our countrymen, and the spoliation of public and private property, was perpetrated with impunity within a mile of the cantonment, and under the very walls of the Bala Hisar. Such an exhibition of weakness on our part taught the enemy their strength – confirmed against us those who, however disposed to join in the rebellion had hitherto kept aloof, and ultimately encouraged the nation to unite as one man for our destruction.'[26] As a first step to this, the rebel leaders decided that rather than prepare for a quick exit they had better organise themselves instead into a provisional government, and elect a leader, without which it was not lawful to declare jihad.

As most of the leading nobles at the beginning of the uprising were Royalists, their first thought was to offer Shah Shuja the chance to expel his